Welcome to your next lesson: The obedience trap.

I'm getting your personalized lesson ready—based on what you've learned, what's next, and the best way for you to build on your skills.

Step by step, you're moving forward.

Ron, let's start with something from real life.

Think of a time you followed an instruction that felt at least a bit wrong, unfair, or unwise (from a boss, parent, teacher, doctor, police, military, manager, etc.). You did it anyway because they were "in charge".

You don't have to share details if it's personal—just answer this:

Were you mainly thinking…

"I don't want trouble / I have to do what they say"?
or
"I truly agree this is the right thing"?

Reply with one of these: "avoid trouble" or "I agreed."

i have to do what they say

That feeling of "I have to do what they say" is exactly what this lesson is about.

I've just pulled up a short documentary on Milgram's obedience experiment 🎥

Watch as much as you can right now—just notice:

What role the scientist/experimenter plays
How the "teacher" reacts as things get more intense

When you're done, tell me: "finished" or "watched most of it," and we'll unpack it step by step.

finished

What do you think? Take your time with the question below 👇

In Milgram's obedience experiment (the video you just watched), which description fits the "teacher" best?

A.

A professional scientist running the study and giving orders

B.

A person who thinks they are giving real electric shocks to the learner when told to

C.

An actor pretending to be in pain in the other room

D.

The person secretly controlling the shock machine from another room

b

Nice, thanks Ron ☑

Let’s zoom in on the core idea from what you watched:

In Milgram’s experiment, most people kept giving shocks because a person in a lab coat calmly said things like:

“The experiment requires that you continue.”
“You have no other choice; you must go on.”

So here’s the one idea for this step:

Obedience = following direct orders from an authority figure, even when you feel it might be wrong.

In the video, the “teacher” was the person pressing the switches, and the authority was the experimenter in the lab coat.

Quick check for you (no right/wrong, just your sense):

When the teachers kept going, did it look more like:

They were bad people, or
The situation and authority pushed them into it?

Just answer: “bad people” or “situation and authority”.

situation oushed them in the settting and the assuned authrity

Exactly 👌 — you’re already thinking like a psychologist here.

In Milgram’s study, most participants weren’t trying to be cruel. The setup did a lot of the pushing:

A serious lab at a respected university
A calm expert in a lab coat saying it was necessary
A clear role: “You are the teacher; I take responsibility”

I want to zoom in on just one piece of that next: the legitimacy of authority (why the man in the lab coat felt like someone you “have to” obey).

Before I explain that, quick check:

In your own life, who feels most like “I have to do what they say,” even if you don’t fully agree?

You can pick one: boss, parent, police, military superior, doctor, teacher, or someone else.

boss at work

That makes a lot of sense. A boss often feels like someone you “have to” obey to keep

your job, avoid conflict, or not be seen as difficult.

Here’s the one concept I want to focus on now:

Legitimacy of authority = how much we see someone as having the right to give us orders.

In Milgram’s study, the man in the lab coat looked and acted like a real scientist at a top university. That made his authority feel very legitimate — so people felt they should obey.

Quick question for you:

If your boss gave you an order that felt wrong, which would pull you more strongly in real life?

You don’t have to explain, just pick one:

“I should obey because they’re my boss”
“I should refuse because it’s wrong”
i should reuse but aas its my job it a conflicty could get firfed for not going along

Exactly — that conflict you just described is the heart of the obedience trap ⚡

On one side:

“This feels wrong, I should refuse.”

On the other side:

“This is my job, my boss has authority, I could get fired.”

Milgram’s study showed how powerful that second side can be when an authority feels legitimate and says, “You must go on.”

Next, I want to walk you step by step through how his experiment was set up — the roles of teacher, learner, and experimenter — using your boss example as a parallel.

Ready for that next small step? Just say “yes” and I’ll lay out the setup clearly and simply.

Yes

Great 👍 let’s go step by step and keep it simple.

Here’s how Milgram’s experiment was set up, in clear roles:

Experimenter – the authority

Wears a lab coat
Calm, serious, in charge
Gives orders like: “Please continue.”
Teacher – the real participant

This is the person like you
Sits at the shock machine
Told: “Your job is to read words and give shocks when the learner is wrong.”

Learner – the victim (actually an actor)

Strapped to a “shock machine” in another room
Purposely makes mistakes
Protests, yells, then goes silent at high “voltage”

The key illusion:

The teacher thinks the shocks are real.
The experimenter keeps saying to continue.
The learner is actually fine, but the teacher doesn’t know that.

At work, this is a bit like:

Boss = experimenter (giving orders, “this is required”)
You = teacher (carrying out the action)
Customer / coworker / public = learner (could be harmed by the decision)
Does this three-role setup make sense so far: experimenter (authority), teacher (you), learner (person being harmed)?

Answer: “yes, clear” or “a bit confused” and I’ll adjust.

yes, clear

What do you think? Pick the best answer in the question box 👇

In Milgram’s experiment, which person was the real participant who thought the shocks were real and followed the experimenter’s orders?

A.

The experimenter in the lab coat

B.

The teacher at the shock machine

C.

The learner in the other room

Nice job, Ron 🎉 You nailed it.

The teacher at the shock machine was the real participant:

They believed the shocks were real.
They felt the stress and conflict.
They were the ones obeying (or trying to resist) the experimenter’s orders.

The experimenter was the authority, and the learner was an actor—only the teacher was truly in the dark.

Next, I want to zoom in on how authority actually pushes behavior (things like the lab coat, the setting, and distance).

Want to focus first on:

“lab coat / expert image” or “being in a famous university building”?

Lab coat / expert image

Great choice — this one is powerful 🔍

Step by step:

When we see a lab coat, clipboard, calm voice, technical language…
Our brain often thinks: “This person is an expert. They know what they’re doing.”
That feeling makes their orders seem more legitimate and harder to question.

In Milgram’s study, many “teachers” kept going because the experimenter looked and sounded like a real scientist who knew the risks and said it was necessary.

In your world, a boss with a title, badge, or professional look can create the same pull:

“I guess they know better… I should do what they say.”

Quick check for you:

Can you think of a real-life situation (work, hospital, school, etc.) where you’d be more likely to obey someone just because they look like an expert (uniform, badge, lab coat, suit)?

You can describe it in one short sentence.

cop win uniform with a badge as they can actually arest you fior refusing

Perfect example, Ron 👮‍♂️

Uniform + badge = instant authority.

Your brain goes:

“This person represents the law.”
“They can arrest or fine me.”
“I have to do what they say, even if I don’t like it.”

That’s legitimacy of authority in action: the symbol (badge, uniform) makes the orders feel non□optional.

Next, I’d like to look at another factor from Milgram: proximity — how physical distance from the victim changed obedience.

Want to go there next? Just say “yes” and I’ll walk through it step by step.

Yes, let's continue

Great, let’s keep it simple and visual 🖋️

In Milgram’s study, proximity means how physically close the teacher was to the learner.

Think of a “distance slider”:

Far away:

Learner in another room
Teacher only hears pounding on the wall or a voice
👉 More obedience (easier to keep going)
Very close:

Teacher in the same room
Or even has to physically hold the learner’s hand on a plate
👉 Less obedience (harder to hurt someone right in front of you)

So:

As the teacher got closer to the learner, obedience dropped.

Does that idea make sense: more distance = easier to obey harmful orders?

Answer “yes” or “not really” and we’ll adjust if needed.

Yes

Let’s connect this to real life for a moment 🌍

Same idea outside the lab:

It’s easier to send a harsh email than say the same words to someone’s face.
It’s easier to click a button that harms a stranger far away than to watch that harm up close.

That’s the power of distance: it softens the emotional impact, so obedience can rise.

Quick gut check, no need to explain a lot:

In your experience, is it easier to do something uncomfortable to someone when:

you only message/call them, or
you’re face to face with them?

Just reply “message/call” or “face to face.”

Message/call

Same here — “message/call” is usually easier because you don’t see their face or reaction. That’s the distance effect you just described in your own words 👍

So far you’ve got:

Legitimacy (lab coat / badge / boss role) makes orders feel like you have to obey.
Distance from the person being hurt makes it emotionally easier to go along.

Next, I’d like to add one more piece: how the situation (not just personality) explains obedience in Milgram’s study.

Want to see that idea next, or pause and recap what we have so far?

Let's see the next idea

Nice, let’s build on what you already have 💪

So when people saw Milgram’s results, many said things like:

“Those teachers must have been cruel or weak.”

That’s a personality (dispositional) explanation.

But Milgram showed something else:

Change the situation → obedience changes a lot.

Examples:

When the experiment was in a prestigious university, obedience was high.
When moved to a run□down office, obedience dropped.
When the experimenter gave orders by telephone, obedience dropped even more.

So psychologists say:

Situational attribution = explaining behavior by the situation people are in, not by "what kind of person" they are.

Quick yes/no:

Does it make sense that in Milgram's study, the setup and conditions explain a lot more than "they were bad people"?

Yes, that makes sense

You're tracking this really well, Ron 👌

Let's pull the pieces together using Milgram's experiment:

Authority influenced behavior through things like:

Legitimacy of authority

Lab coat, university setting, calm expert tone
Teachers felt: "He knows what he's doing; he has the right to tell me what to do."
Proximity

Being farther from the learner (in another room) → more obedience
Being closer (same room, touching) → less obedience
Institutional context

Prestigious university → more trust, more "this must be safe / important"
Run-down office → less trust, obedience dropped

All of that shows:

Ordinary people, in a strong authority situation, can obey orders they feel are wrong.

Now I want to check your understanding with one focused question:

In Milgram's variations, which change reduced obedience the most?

Reply with just A, B, or C (no need to explain):

A) Moving from university to a run□down office

B) Experimenter giving orders by telephone

C) Putting teacher and learner in the same room

b

Exactly right, Ron 🎯

B) Experimenter giving orders by telephone reduced obedience the most.

Why?

The authority felt less present and powerful.
With the experimenter out of the room, people felt freer to disobey.
This shows how much immediate, physical authority can push behavior.

You've now hit the key outcome for this lesson: using Milgram's experiment to explain how authority (legitimacy, proximity, setting) shapes what people do.

Before we wrap this lesson up:

Do you want to:

ask anything that still feels fuzzy, or
move on to the next lesson?
can move on

Nice work today, Ron 🎉

Here's what you're taking with you from The obedience trap:

In Milgram's experiment, the teacher was the real participant who thought the shocks were real and obeyed the experimenter.
Authority influences behavior through:
Legitimacy: lab coat, badge, title, respected setting → "they have the right to tell me what to do."
Proximity: closer authority → more pressure; closer victim → harder to obey harmful orders.
Institutional context: big university or formal setting → more trust, more obedience.
The big idea: much of the shocking obedience came from the situation, not from people being "bad."
You connected this to your own life (boss, cops, message vs face□to□face), which shows real understanding 💡

When you're ready, you can jump into the next lesson from your Learn tab, and I'll be here to walk through it with you step by step.